GURU MANTRAS

Wise men have always been part of the Indian tradition, helping humanity navigate the ups and downs of everyday life. Keeping that practice alive are this set of religious savants. Here are their words of wisdom

"Focus on yourself"

By **SWAMI GAUR GOPAL DAS**

When the state of your mind changes or is negative, even the best of things stop giving pleasure and happiness. But when the state of mind is right, even the simplest things can bring joy. So, the mind can turn heaven into hell or hell into heaven. We need to learn about how to deal with the mind, and how to master our thoughts, emotions and feelings.

When we are constantly looking at others or are being compared to others, we start feeling inadequate. We start feeling we are not enough. That pressure and stress to feel more than enough and trying to be somebody else has taken away the authenticity of life. The problem arises when we get into the mode of looking at others constantly. The more you look at the lives of others, the more you feel your own life is not good or adequate enough. Remember, you have everything in your life at the moment to live a happy life. Focus on yourself.

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Stop being obsessed with the need to be happy all the time. Accept your emotions with full authenticity"

I am often asked about maintaining that state of happiness when not feeling happy. We all go through a range of emotions in the course of a day. So, stop being overly obsessed with being happy and positive and the need to be smiling all the time. There is no need to smile all the time. There is no need to be happy all the time. The pressure to be happy and positive is making you negative and miserable. That pressure is toxic and it becomes toxic positivity. Accept your emotions with full authenticity. It's fine to feel low as long as you don't feel low all the time in a chronic way. Stop taking the pressure.

We all have, and go through, pains and struggles in life. If someone is smiling, it doesn't mean they don't have to struggle. Learn to change what you can do about your pain. But also remember there are going to be things that you can't change. Learn to smile, accept what you can't change, and learn to rise above it. Spirituality, mindfulness and meditation are therefore important. So are conscious breathing and being in your space to be able to come to terms.

Choose to look at the brighter side and deal with the negative side of life. No individual in the world can fulfil your expectations. There will be toxic people around. Draw your boundaries, speak clearly and communicate well. We are all work in progress. ■

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